

pur also says that many brands in the wellness categories sold quickly. “In that wave, established pharma brands like Zincovit, Becosules, etc. also became popular.”

“For many years now, healthcare professionals have trusted the Becosules brand and encouraged the use of the many products in the portfolio to provide adequate amount of micronutrients,” says S. Sridhar, Managing Director of Pfizer Limited, which manufactures Becosules. “The pandemic has emphasised the importance of preventive health and the need to build immunity. Vitamin B complex and vitamin C are important for optimum functioning of our body, which is why we saw an increase in the use of Becosules during this time,” says Sridhar.

The scenario was quite different in the first half of 2021, when the second wave of the pandemic wreaked havoc on both patients and the medical community. At that time, the pharma industry had reasonable growth on account of Covid-19-related products like Remdesivir, and vitamins and minerals received a boost as supplemental products. Pharmaceutical experts believe that it also led to much better hygiene practices due to the adoption of Covid-19 appropriate behaviour. Due to this, the non-Covid-19 acute therapy business was impacted, but as the second wave started reducing, people started coming out of their homes and were exposed to the weather and seasonal changes.

On the other hand, the first wave of the pandemic, in terms of pharma sales trends, was similar to the third wave because nobody knew how to treat Covid-19. “The medical fraternity was not able to put its finger on the

cause and hence wisely chose to treat the symptoms as best as it could. This period saw exponential growth in the sales of some very standard medicines like anti-pyretic drugs and supplements geared towards treating high grades of fever and boosting immunity. The likes of Remdesivir, Lopinavir-Ritonavir, Favipiravir, and such treatments became the primary line of treatment for critically ill patients,” says Raheel Shah, Director, BDR Pharmaceuticals, which is one of the manufacturers of anti-Covid-19 drug Molnupiravir.

“In very critical cases, more potent drugs like Tocilizumab were also administered for treatment and yielded positive results. Drug sales have spiked in the past two years, especially the critical care, OTC vitamins, and other antibiotics. The trend has continued, however, post-Covid as clinics have become more functional, and drug sales of derma and oncological injectables have also started to pick up,” says Shah.

Will the Momentum Sustain?

The Covid-19 pandemic threw open opportunities for some drugs, which at one point in time became difficult to procure such as Remdesivir and some steroid brands in the second wave, and Dolo, Zincovit and others in the third wave. As the pandemic has receded, the popularity and demand looks difficult to sustain. “Pandemics will never make a company rich, because pandemics come and go, so there could be opportunities for very few companies,” says Satyanarayana Chava, Founder & CEO, Laurus Labs, adding as an example that Dolo 650 became popular and almost a synonym for Paracetamol.

Jayaraj holds a view that a similar pattern will show up in future pandemics, too. “Drugs like Paracetamol, Azithromycin, Favipiravir, Doxycycline, Corticosteroids and immune boosters were recommended by Indian Council of Medical Research (ICMR) for the treatment of Covid and the leading brands in these segments gained immensely,” he says, adding that Dolo 650 being the leader in the Paracetamol market, garnered huge prescriptions and gained immense popularity.

True, but now we are back to the question: Can the momentum sustain? And the answer seems to be a clear ‘no’. Data from IQVIA shows that Dolo 650, Azithral and Calpol, which saw spike in sales in January due to the third wave of Covid-19, are no longer in the top 25 brands in February, in terms of sales. Instead, the top-selling drug brand in February was Mixtard, a drug used for managing diabetes, from Novo Nordisk, a Danish multinational pharmaceutical company. So, the Covid-19 opportunity for non-Covid-19 drugs seems to have come and gone, and is not likely to come back unless there is another wave. And that is something no one would wish for. **BT**

GROWTH NUMBERS

Azithromycin Oral Solids observed the highest growth of **250%** for January 2022

Azithral ranks No. 1 among the top **25 products** in January 2022



Dolo grew **307%**, in a month, the maximum amongst the top 10 brands

In the top 10, Calpol, another antipyretic, grew **261%** in a month

Azithral has become the topmost brand with **₹73 crore** sales in January 2022

SOURCE: AWACS